

Claude-Code-Setup-Guide

Part 2: Installing Claude Code

You're about to install the tool we'll use throughout the rest of this program. This is the single most important setup step. Everything else builds on this.

In Part 1, I talked about the difference between chatting with AI and building with AI. ChatGPT is chatting. Claude Code is building. It lives on your computer. It reads your files. It creates things. It remembers your project from session to session.

Right now, none of that matters. Right now, all that matters is getting it installed and running. Don't worry about understanding everything yet. Just follow the steps. You'll type exactly what I tell you to type, and at the end, you'll have your first building experience with AI.

This takes about 30-45 minutes. If you've done this kind of thing before, you might finish in 10.

What You're Looking At: The Terminal

A terminal is a text-based way to talk to your computer. Instead of clicking icons, you type commands. It looks intimidating. It isn't. You'll type exactly what I tell you to type.

Here's how to open it:

Mac:

Press `Cmd + Space` to open Spotlight Search. Type `Terminal`. Press Enter. A window will open with a blinking cursor.

[SCREENSHOT: Mac Spotlight search showing "Terminal" with Terminal.app highlighted]

Windows:

Click the Start button (or press the Windows key). Type `PowerShell`. Click "Windows PowerShell" when it appears. A blue window will open with a blinking cursor.

[SCREENSHOT: Windows Start menu showing "Windows PowerShell" search result]

That blinking cursor is where you'll type commands. When I show you a command in this guide, type it exactly as written and press Enter.

Already Have Claude Code Installed?

If you've installed Claude Code before, skip to **Step 5: Your First Run** to verify everything is working. If something breaks, come back and redo the earlier steps.

Step 1: Check for Node.js (Mac Only)

Claude Code's native installer handles everything automatically on both platforms. But on Mac, if you plan to use Homebrew (a popular package manager), you may want Node.js available. Windows users can skip this step entirely -- the Windows installer handles everything.

Mac users: In your Terminal, type this command and press Enter:

```
node --version
```

What does this do? It asks your computer: "Do you have Node.js installed?" Node.js is a tool that runs JavaScript on your computer. Some installation methods for Claude Code need it.

If you see a version number (like `v20.11.0` or `v22.3.1`) -- you're good. Move on to Step 2.

If you see "command not found: node" -- that's fine. The native installer we'll use in Step 2 doesn't require Node.js. Just move on.

[SCREENSHOT: Terminal showing `node --version` output with a version number]

Step 2: Install Claude Code

Here's where you install the actual tool. The command is different for Mac and Windows.

Mac:

Open Terminal (if it's not already open) and type this command, then press Enter:

```
curl -fsSL https://claude.ai/install.sh | bash
```

What does this do? It downloads the Claude Code installer from Anthropic's website and runs it. Think of it like double-clicking a setup file, except you're doing it from the terminal.

Windows:

Open PowerShell (if it's not already open) and type this command, then press Enter:

```
irm https://claude.ai/install.ps1 | iex
```

What does this do? Same thing as the Mac command -- downloads and runs the Claude Code installer -- but using Windows' PowerShell syntax.

What to expect (both platforms): You'll see text scroll by for 10-30 seconds. That's normal. It's downloading and setting up Claude Code. Wait until you see a message confirming installation is complete and a new blinking cursor appears.

[SCREENSHOT: Successful Claude Code installation output on Mac]

[SCREENSHOT: Successful Claude Code installation output on Windows]

After installation, close your terminal and open a fresh one. This ensures your computer recognizes the new `claude` command. On Mac, open a new Terminal. On Windows, open a new PowerShell.

Verify the installation worked. In your fresh terminal, type:

```
claude --version
```

You should see a version number. If you do, Claude Code is installed. Move on to Step 3.

[SCREENSHOT: Terminal showing `claude --version` output]

Step 3: Choose Your Plan

Claude Code requires either a Claude subscription or an Anthropic API account. Here are your two options:

Option A: Claude Pro or Max Subscription (Recommended for Most People)

This is the simplest path. You pay one monthly subscription, and it covers both Claude on the web AND Claude Code in your terminal.

Pricing:

- **Claude Pro:** \$20/month -- includes Claude Code access
- **Claude Max 5x:** \$100/month -- 5x the capacity of Pro
- **Claude Max 20x:** \$200/month -- 20x the capacity of Pro

If you already have a Claude Pro or Max subscription, you're set. Move on to Step 4.

If you need to subscribe:

1. Go to **claude.ai** in your browser
2. Click "Get started" or "Sign up"
3. Create an account with your email
4. Choose the Pro plan (\$20/month) -- you can always upgrade later
5. Enter your payment information
6. You now have a Claude account

Option B: Anthropic API (Pay-Per-Use)

This option charges you based on how much you use Claude Code, rather than a flat monthly fee. A typical session costs somewhere between \$0.50 and \$2.00, depending on how much work you're asking Claude to do.

When this makes sense: If you only plan to use Claude Code occasionally, pay-per-use might be cheaper than \$20/month. If you'll use it regularly (which you will in this program), the Pro subscription is almost always the better deal.

If you choose this path:

1. Go to **console.anthropic.com** in your browser
2. Create an account (or sign in if you have one)
3. You'll need to add a payment method under Billing

4. That's it for now -- Claude Code will walk you through connecting your account in Step 4

A note on costs: Whether you choose a subscription or pay-per-use, this is NOT free. The Pro plan is \$20/month. Pay-per-use will vary. This program will teach you to manage costs effectively. For now, just know that you're paying for a building tool, not a chat toy -- and it costs far less than hiring someone to do this work for you.

Step 4: Connect Your Account to Claude Code

Now you need to tell Claude Code who you are so it can use your account.

In your terminal, type:

```
claude
```

What does this do? It starts Claude Code for the first time.

The first time you run Claude Code, it will walk you through authentication. Here's what to expect:

If You Have a Claude Pro/Max Subscription (Option A):

Claude Code will open your browser and ask you to log in to your Claude account. Log in with the same email you used for your subscription. Approve the connection when prompted. Return to your terminal.

Important: If you previously set an environment variable called `ANTHROPIC_API_KEY`, Claude Code will use that instead of your subscription -- which means you'll be charged per-use on TOP of your subscription. If you're on a Pro or Max plan and want to use your subscription's included usage, make sure no API key is set. (If you don't know what an environment variable is, you're fine -- you haven't set one.)

If You're Using the API (Option B):

Claude Code will ask how you want to authenticate. Choose the Console option. It will open your browser and take you through an authentication flow. Follow the prompts, approve the connection, and return to your terminal.

You should see Claude Code's welcome screen -- a message from Claude, ready to take your first instruction.

[SCREENSHOT: Claude Code welcome screen after successful authentication]

If something went wrong, check the **Troubleshooting** section at the bottom of this guide.

Step 5: Your First Run -- The "It's Working" Moment

Let's make sure everything actually works. You're going to give Claude Code a simple instruction, and it's going to create a real file on your computer.

First, navigate to your Desktop so the file shows up somewhere you can easily find it.

Mac:

```
cd ~/Desktop
```

Windows:

```
cd $HOME\Desktop
```

What does this do? It tells your terminal: "Go to my Desktop folder." Any files created here will appear on your actual Desktop.

Now, if Claude Code isn't already running, start it:

```
claude
```

Claude Code will start up. You'll see a prompt where you can type natural language instructions.

Type this (replacing "YOUR NAME" with your actual name):

```
Create a file called test.md with the text "Hello, my name is YOUR NAME. This file was created by Claude Code."
```

Press Enter.

What to expect: Claude Code will create the file. It may ask for your permission to write to the filesystem the first time -- say yes (type `y` and press Enter). You should see a confirmation that the file was created.

Now check: go to your Desktop (the actual Desktop on your screen, not the terminal). You should see a file called `test.md`.

[SCREENSHOT: Claude Code creating test.md file and confirmation message]

[SCREENSHOT: Desktop showing the test.md file]

Open it. It should contain the text you requested.

Congratulations. You just had your first building experience with AI.

That file is real. It's sitting on your computer. Claude Code didn't just tell you about a file -- it MADE one. That's the difference between chatting and building. And that's what we'll be doing for the rest of this program.

To exit Claude Code, type `/exit` and press Enter. Or just close the terminal window.

Step 6: What NOT to Worry About

You might have seen references to some of these things online. Ignore them for now:

- **CLAUDE.md files** -- You'll learn about these in the program. Not now.
- **Skills and agents** -- Program content. Not now.
- **VS Code or IDE integration** -- Optional and advanced. Not now.
- **MCP servers** -- You don't need to know what this is yet.
- **Slash commands** -- You'll pick these up naturally during the program.
- **Memorizing commands** -- The program will teach you as we go. You don't need to memorize anything from this guide.

Right now, all that matters is: **can you type `claude` and get a response?**

If yes, you're done with Part 2.

Troubleshooting

If something went wrong, find your error below. Every error has a fix.

"command not found: claude"

What it means: Your computer doesn't recognize the `claude` command. Either the installation didn't complete, or your terminal can't find where Claude Code was installed.

Fix (both platforms):

1. Close your terminal completely and open a fresh one. Try `claude` again. Sometimes the terminal just needs to be restarted.
2. If that doesn't work, re-run the installation command:

Mac:

```
curl -fsSL https://claude.ai/install.sh | bash
```

Windows:

```
irm https://claude.ai/install.ps1 | iex
```

Then close the terminal, open a new one, and try `claude` again.

3. **Mac only:** If it still doesn't work, try adding the install location to your PATH. Type this:

```
echo 'export PATH="$HOME/.local/bin:$PATH"' >> ~/.zshrc && source ~/.zshrc
```

What does this do? It tells your Mac where to find the Claude Code program every time you open a terminal.

Then try `claude` again.

4. **Windows only:** If it still doesn't work after re-running the installer, try closing PowerShell and opening it again **as Administrator** (right-click PowerShell and choose "Run as Administrator"). Then re-run the install command.

"command not found: node" (Mac)

What it means: Node.js isn't installed on your Mac. But good news -- the native Claude Code installer doesn't require it.

Fix: If you ran the native install command from Step 2 and Claude Code works, ignore this. You don't need Node.js.

If you need Node.js for another reason:

1. Go to **nodejs.org** in your browser
 2. Click the big green button that says "LTS" (Long Term Support)
 3. Download and run the installer
 4. Follow the prompts (accept the defaults)
 5. Close and reopen Terminal
 6. Type `node --version` to verify
-

"Error: ANTHROPIC_API_KEY is invalid" or "Authentication failed"

What it means: Claude Code can't verify your identity. Either your API key is wrong, your subscription isn't active, or the authentication process didn't complete.

Fix for subscription users (Pro/Max):

1. Run `claude logout` to clear any existing authentication
2. Run `claude login` to start fresh
3. When the browser opens, make sure you're logging in with the SAME email that has your Pro or Max subscription
4. Complete the authentication process in the browser
5. Return to the terminal -- Claude Code should now work

Fix for API users:

1. Go to **console.anthropic.com**
 2. Check that your account is active and has billing set up
 3. Run `claude logout` then `claude login`
 4. Choose the Console authentication option
 5. Complete the process in your browser
-

"Permission denied" or "EACCES" Error (Mac)

What it means: Your Mac is blocking the installation because of file permissions.

Fix:

Do NOT use `sudo` (that creates different problems). Instead, try this:

```
mkdir -p ~/.local/bin  
curl -fsSL https://claude.ai/install.sh | bash
```

What does this do? It creates the installation directory first with your user permissions, then runs the installer.

If you still get permission errors, try installing via Homebrew instead:

```
brew install --cask claude-code
```

If you don't have Homebrew, install it first:

```
/bin/bash -c "$(curl -fsSL https://raw.githubusercontent.com/Homebrew/install/HEAD/install.sh)"
```

Then try `brew install --cask claude-code` again.

"Execution of scripts is disabled on this system" (Windows)

What it means: Windows PowerShell has a security setting that blocks scripts from running.

Fix:

1. Close PowerShell
2. Open PowerShell **as Administrator** (right-click, "Run as Administrator")
3. Type this command and press Enter:

```
Set-ExecutionPolicy -ExecutionPolicy RemoteSigned -Scope CurrentUser
```

4. Type `Y` and press Enter to confirm

5. Now run the Claude Code installer again:

```
irm https://claude.ai/install.ps1 | iex
```

"Network error" or "Connection timed out"

What it means: Your computer can't reach the Claude Code servers. This is usually a network issue.

Fix:

1. Check your internet connection -- can you open a website in your browser?
 2. If you're on a corporate or office network, that network may be blocking the connection. Try from a personal Wi-Fi network or a mobile hotspot.
 3. If you're using a VPN, try disconnecting it temporarily and running the install again.
 4. Try again in a few minutes -- sometimes it's a temporary server issue on Anthropic's end.
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"Claude Code starts but doesn't respond" or "Session hangs"

What it means: Claude Code launched but something is wrong with the connection to the AI service.

Fix:

1. Type `/exit` to quit Claude Code (or press `Ctrl + C` twice)
2. Run `claude doctor` -- this checks your installation for problems

```
claude doctor
```

3. Read the output. It will tell you what's wrong and suggest fixes.
 4. If `claude doctor` says everything is fine, close your terminal, wait 30 seconds, open a new terminal, and try `claude` again.
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Nothing Here Fixes My Problem

If you've tried everything above and you're still stuck:

1. Take a screenshot of your error (the whole terminal window)
2. Note which step you're on
3. Note whether you're on Mac or Windows
4. Email our support team at **[SUPPORT EMAIL]** with the screenshot and details

We'll get you unstuck. Don't spend more than 15 minutes wrestling with an error -- that's what support is for.

You're Done When...

- ☐ You can type `claude` in your terminal and Claude Code responds
- ☐ You asked Claude to create a file and it appeared on your Desktop
- ☐ You know approximately what Claude Code costs (either your subscription plan or ~\$0.50-\$2.00 per session on pay-per-use)

If all three boxes are checked, you're ready.

Next up: Part 3 -- you'll install Obsidian, where all your files and project context will live. Then in Part 4, you'll have your first real working session with Claude Code, where it interviews YOU about your business. That's where the building starts in earnest.

Part 2 of the Client Grounding Package | Strategic Profits

Estimated completion time: 30-45 minutes